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PRESIDENCY DESK · BRIEF 5 OF 5

Critical Infrastructure Resilience

Ireland published its Critical Entities Resilience Strategy weeks before assuming the Council Presidency. It now chairs the body where every other member state's implementation is reviewed. The question is whether Ireland treats this as compliance or as a platform for EU-wide leadership on infrastructure protection.

Security Ireland

2026

IN BRIEF

Ireland's National Strategy on the Resilience of Critical Entities, published 12 February 2026, implements the EU CER Directive across eleven sectors: energy, transport, banking, financial market infrastructure, health, drinking water, waste water, digital infrastructure, public administration, space, and food. The Department of Defence acts as the single point of contact. Competent Authorities are designated for each sector.

Three EU frameworks intersect during Ireland's Presidency: the CER Directive implementation across all 27 member states, the NIS 2 Directive for cyber resilience, and the Critical Entities Resilience Group's work programme. Ireland chairs the Council that receives member state strategies and can set the standard for how cross-border infrastructure dependencies are governed.

The strategy commits to formalised cross-border coordination with the United Kingdom on shared critical infrastructure—a novel governance challenge, since the CER Directive was designed for intra-EU cooperation.

The strategic objective

Ireland’s strategic objective for the Presidency is to establish itself as a permanent, credible contributor to European security in the domains where its geography is irreplaceable—maritime surveillance, subsea infrastructure protection, and cyber resilience—so that when the Presidency ends in December 2026, Ireland has locked in a role that outlasts the political window.

Critical infrastructure resilience is the domain where Ireland’s domestic action and EU leadership converge most directly. Ireland is one of the first member states to publish a national CER strategy ahead of assuming the Council chair. This is not a compliance exercise, it is a credibility platform.

> **WHY CRITICAL INFRASTRUCTURE RESILIENCE MATTERS FOR THIS OBJECTIVE**
> Critical infrastructure resilience is the connective tissue between Ireland’s domestic security reforms and its European positioning. The CER Strategy covers the same sectors the other Presidency Desk briefs address from different angles: energy and subsea cables (Maritime Surveillance brief), digital infrastructure and cyber (Hybrid Threats brief), and defence industrial prerequisites (ReArm Europe brief). The CER framework is the regulatory architecture through which these sectors are identified, risk-assessed, and governed. Ireland chairing its implementation gives it authority across all four domains simultaneously.

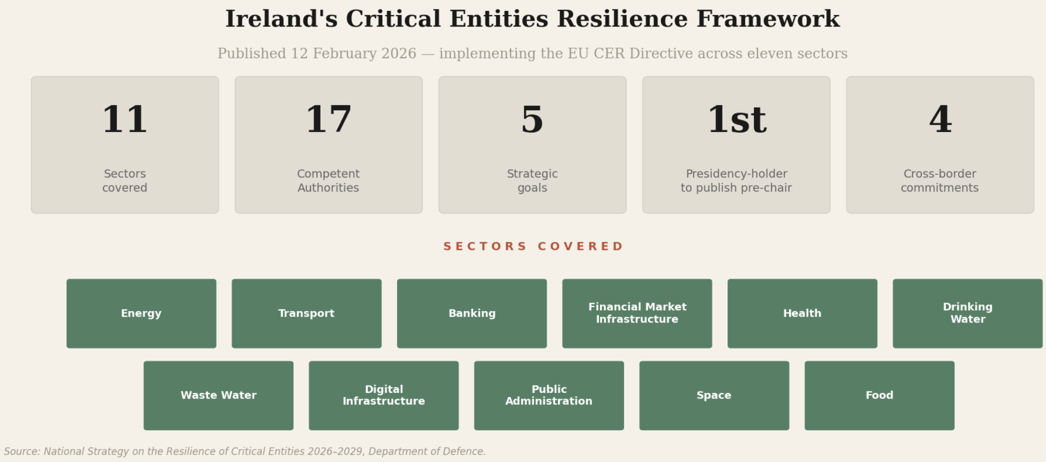

Figure 1: Ireland’s Critical Entities Resilience Framework. Eleven sectors, seventeen Competent Authorities, five strategic goals.

Ireland’s domestic position

Ireland’s CER Strategy establishes a governance framework more detailed than most member states have achieved. The Department of Defence acts as the single point of contact and Competent Authorities are designated for each sector—the Commission for Regulation of Utilities for energy, the Irish Aviation Authority for air transport, the Central Bank for banking and financial market infrastructure, the Environmental Protection Agency for water, and the Commission for Communications Regulation for digital infrastructure.

Critical Entities must conduct risk assessments within nine months of designation, drawing on the National Risk Assessment. They must implement resilience measures across four components—resistance, reliability, redundancy, and response and recovery—benchmarked against international standards including ISO 22301, ISO 22372, and ISO 27001.

The strategy commits to formalised engagement with the UK on shared critical infrastructure, and explicitly addresses the intersection with NIS 2 and DORA, committing to coordination between the Department of Defence and the National Cyber Security Centre.

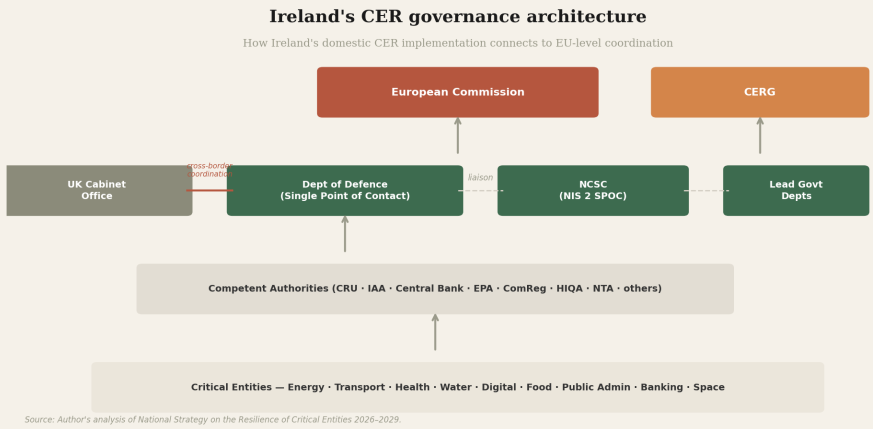

Figure 3: Ireland's CER governance architecture. The Department of Defence as single point of contact, coordinating with NCSC, Competent Authorities, and the UK.

What's being decided during Ireland's term

Three CER-related processes reach decision points during Ireland's Presidency. Each determines whether Ireland's early implementation becomes a template or an isolated exercise.

1. The CERG work programme

The Critical Entities Resilience Group supports the Commission in coordinating implementation. Ireland chairs the Council during the period when the CERG's initial work programme is operationalised; Ireland's detailed national strategy positions it to shape these standards rather than receive them.

2. Member state compliance reporting

Member states must submit national strategies and essential services lists to the Commission, and Ireland chairs the Council when compliance divergences become visible. Thus, Ireland can set the expectation for quality of implementation—using its own strategy as a benchmark.

3. Non-EU cross-border infrastructure governance

Ireland's strategy commits to formalised engagement with the UK. The Directive was designed for intra-EU coordination. Ireland's Presidency can establish the precedent for how EU critical infrastructure governance interfaces with non-EU neighbours.

4. CER–NIS 2 operational alignment

Critical Entities under CER are automatically Essential Entities under NIS 2. The practical alignment of physical and cyber resilience obligations is being worked out during 2026. Ireland's Presidency can drive EU-wide guidance preventing duplication.

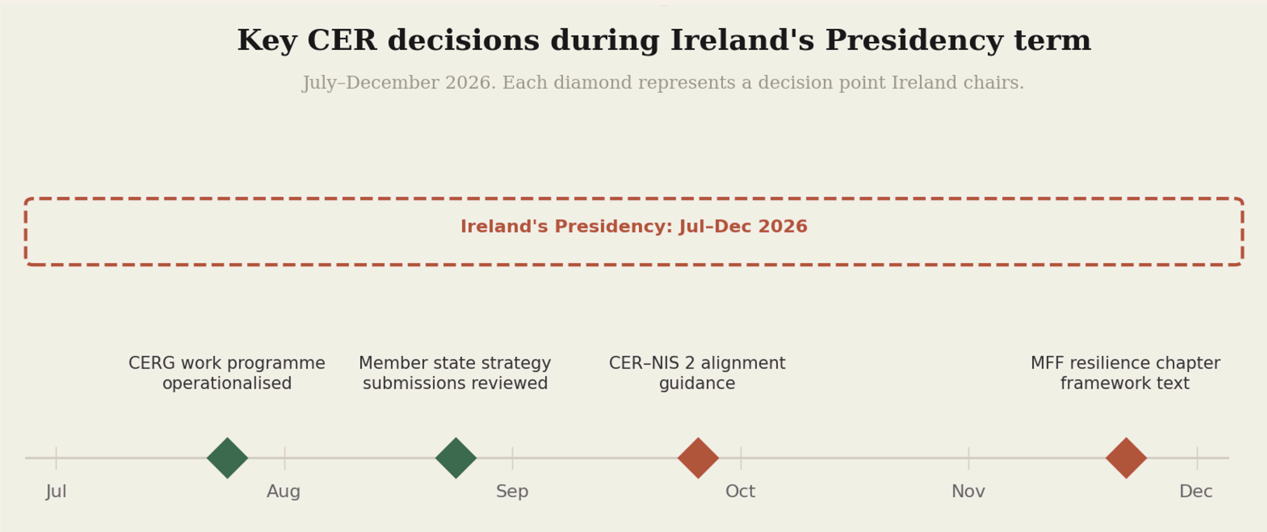

Figure 2: Key CER decisions during Ireland's Presidency term (July–December 2026).

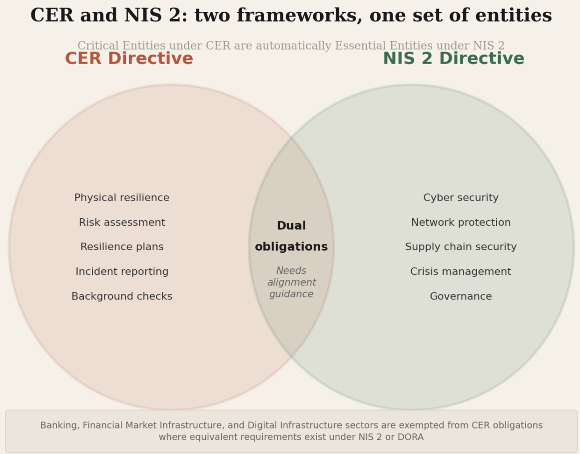

Figure 4: CER and NIS 2: two frameworks, one set of entities. Practical alignment guidance is needed during Ireland's Presidency.

What Ireland should do

Four actions, each justified by how it advances the strategic objective of converting Ireland's early CER implementation into a permanent European security contribution.

1. Present Ireland's CER strategy as a model at the CERG

Ireland should present its national strategy—including the detailed appendices on Critical Entity identification methodology, risk assessment guidance, and resilience measures—as a working model for the CERG. The strategy's four-step identification process and resilience guidance benchmarked against international standards are more detailed than what most member states have published.

THIS LOCKS IN: *Ireland as the member state that set the implementation standard for CER. Standards proposed during the Presidency persist as reference frameworks.*

2. Establish the precedent for non-EU cross-border infrastructure coordination

Ireland should present its bilateral UK framework to the CERG and the Commission as a model for EU–non-EU critical infrastructure governance. The Cork MoU provides the bilateral governance layer; the CER cross-border commitment provides the infrastructure-specific coordination layer.

THIS LOCKS IN: *A precedent for how EU critical infrastructure resilience interfaces with non-EU neighbours. Ireland defines the governance model.*

3. Drive practical CER–NIS 2 alignment guidance

Ireland should use its Presidency to commission EU-wide guidance on practical alignment of CER and NIS 2 obligations. The Presidency can mandate the CERG and the NIS Cooperation Group to produce joint guidance on unified risk assessment, coordinated incident reporting, aligned supervision, and harmonised resilience metrics.

THIS LOCKS IN: *Ireland as the Presidency that solved the CER–NIS 2 coherence problem before it became a compliance burden.*

4. Embed critical infrastructure resilience in MFF framework text

The next MFF should name critical infrastructure resilience as a funded priority domain—distinct from military capability. If the MFF treats resilience as a subset of defence spending, Ireland's 0.2% of GDP makes it irrelevant; if critical infrastructure resilience is a named category, Ireland's geographic position gives it a permanent claim on EU resources.

THIS LOCKS IN: *Critical infrastructure resilience as a permanent, funded category in the EU budget.*

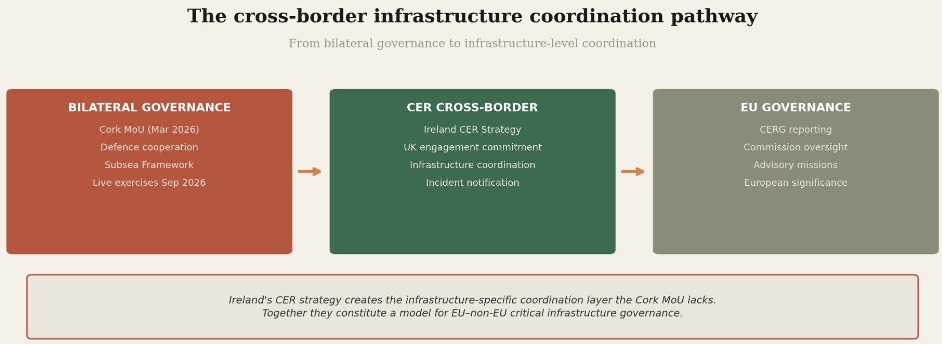

Figure 5: The cross-border infrastructure coordination pathway. From bilateral governance (Cork MoU) through CER coordination to EU-level reporting.

What happens if Ireland doesn't act

The CERG work programme is shaped by larger member states. Germany, France, and the Netherlands set the implementation standards, and Ireland's detailed strategy becomes a national curiosity rather than an EU benchmark.

Cross-border governance defaults to intra-EU models. Ireland's UK dimension—shared energy grids, shared maritime approaches, shared subsea cable corridors—has no governance framework at the infrastructure level.

CER and NIS 2 implementation diverges. Without Presidency-level pressure for practical alignment, the two frameworks develop separate compliance cultures and separate reporting systems.

The MFF treats resilience as a subset of defence. EU resilience funding flows through defence channels where Ireland's 0.2% spending makes it structurally irrelevant.

Figure 6: What Ireland locks in through active chairing — and what it loses through passive chairing.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Ireland published its CER strategy before any other Presidency-holder has done so in the context of assuming the chair. This is an asset—but only if it is used. A strategy that sits on the Department of Defence website is a compliance document. A strategy that is presented to the CERG as a model, that shapes the cross-border governance precedent, that drives CER–NIS 2 alignment, and that anchors the MFF resilience funding line is a Presidency contribution. The difference is whether Ireland treats critical infrastructure resilience as emergency planning or as strategic positioning.

Fifth in the Presidency Desk series—five briefs on the EU instruments Ireland must steer during its Council Presidency. Companion briefs: ReArm Europe; PESCO Strategic Review; Maritime Surveillance Cooperation; Hybrid Threats and Cyber Defence.

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